Jawan, for which Khan signed on Tamil director Atlee, showed how cued-in the actor was with the shifts in Indian cinema and the pan-India potential of regional filmmakers



(IM)PERFECT HERO
A poster of *Jawan*

clare Pathaan *"zinda hai"* to his antagonists. In *Jawan*, Khan played not only the jailer son but also the ex-armyman, salt-and-pepper-haired, old-school-rock-fan father who rides a motorcyle and refuses to give up his cigar even when taking down the bad guys—only, he has total memory loss, walks with a heavy gait, and his closest friends are anything but in their youthful prime. Here was the very picture of Bollywood juvenescence embracing the colours of fall and a gritty premonition of winter—in some style at that.

Jawan also showed how cued-in Khan is with the rest of the country, alive to the pan-India potential of regional filmmakers. It meant signing on Tamil filmmaker Atlee for a Rs 300 crore Hindi film, the 34-year-old's first foray outside his linguistic domain. It was a gamble, but it paid off. Inter alia, *Jawan* became Khan's highest grosser in the South, earning Rs 55 crore in Tamil and Rs 39 crore in Telugu. Not much compared to the national takehome, but still a first. Even his peers from the born-in-'65 club, Aamir and Salman, have struggled to pierce that frontier. Shah Rukh's success is a function of how he keeps himself up to speed on all things. That he shunned press conferences to instead engage with his fans directly on X shows that.

"Jab meri film release hoti hai, uss din Eid hoti hi hai ["The day my film releases, it's Eid"]," Khan had said to cheers at a success event for *Jawan*. He couldn't quite get to repeat that line with his third release at the tail end of 2023. His second home production, *Dunki* was a paler realisation of his own standards, denying him a hat-trick of blockbusters. But the film still managed to cross the Rs 100 crore mark in India despite middling reviews. *"Humein hi karna padega, bhai. Bachchon pe nahin chhod sakte* ["We will have to do it, brother. Can't leave it to the kids"]," the 58-year-old actor says rather clairvoyantly to Salman's Tiger towards the close of *Pathaan*. Count that as a memo to Bollywood too, for indeed, when obituaries were being written about the Hindi film industry as well as his own career, it was Shah Rukh Khan himself who stepped up and delivered two of its biggest hits. Pathaan is not just alive—he is flourishing. Still very much the undisputed 'Badshah' of Bollywood, he's not afraid of redefining himself. ■